You will have to go out, reach house-to-house and you will have to acquaint people with the lotus sign. You will have to teach them how to press the button next to the lotus sign. You will have to fit into people's minds that voting [matdaan] comes before jalpaan [drinking water]. Let mothers in families decide that until you go and vote, you will not get morning tea, won't get morning breakfast. See what a big revolution this will be. And can you decide that in the polling booths you work in, you can get more women to vote than men? If men give 350 votes, women must give 400 votes. If men give 500 votes, women must put 600 votes. You make your minds determined on this. Be competitive. Let women decide. Encourage women to come forward to protect women.

While the deep focus on women was part of the 'Modi model',[87] as one BJP office-bearer told me, some of the early groundwork for reaching out to women voters and incorporating the lessons of the Gujarat model started under the presidency of Rajnath Singh (2005–2009) and Nitin Gadkari (2009–2013). This period, when the BJP was still recovering from its shock election loss in 2004, was also when it started new organisational initiatives, of which outreach to women was an important part, following on from the party's formal commitment in 2003 to support legislation for 33 per cent reservation for women in Parliament and state legislatures.[88] While that promise has since languished, its adoption within the party structure signalled the beginning of a shift. 'Many more women started coming into the party,' recalls Vani Tripathi Tikoo, who served as BJP national secretary at the time. 'Rajnath Singh started being in favour of 33 per cent reservation for women at the party.' Smriti Irani, already a national face as the ideal bahu in Ekta Kapur's television blockbuster, *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*, was among the new recruits to the party at the time. She was appointed women's wing president and party spokesperson.

This was around the time of the Nirbhaya incident in Delhi and the BJP made women's safety a core concern in the MCD elections in Delhi, with a focus on sexual harassment as a primary political issue. 'This campaign was national in character,' says Tikoo, who played a central role in creating the campaign. 'It was about